

SMALL TOWN WINNERS

The ethnic divide unites in a series of new soaps as television channels woo small town audiences with local customs, dialects and costumes



INTERIOR COUNTRY: *Bidaai*, the story of two Agra girls (left); *Raja ki Aayegi Baraat* based in Palampur



WHY GO DESI?

- Share of general entertainment category is declining, from 21.3 per cent in 2004 to 20.2 per cent in 2007.
- New channels are cloning the leaders, so the lead channels are forced to innovate.
- Regional focus works. Sixty per cent of *Bidaai*'s audience is from the Hindi heartland.
- Cable households are growing in non-metros (from 70 to 72 per cent between 2002-06) and declining in the eight metros (23 per cent to 19 per cent).

Sources: TAM for TRPs; NRS for Cable figures

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

In 1977, actor Dheeraj Kumar shot 19 Punjabi films over three years. One of them was shot in Mullapur Garibdass, near Chandigarh, a picture postcard vision of a prosperous Punjab *pind*. Almost 30 years on, he went back to the village, found an all-marble, all-white farmhouse in the middle of a *sarson da khet*, borrowed it from the former army captain for a month and shot his production house, Creative Eye's new serial *Veeranwali* there. The show, on 9X, is one of the several new small town daughters-of-the-soil soaps, which are popping up in spaces previously reserved for bejewelled jowly ladies running families spanning generations.

Just as Bollywood discovered desi cool with *Bunty Aur Babli*, recognising

the pluck and pugnacity of places which previously had fallen off the map, now Star Plus is leading the charge of the small town brigade on television, going as far as Agra for its new winner *Bidaai* (which with a TRP of 5.42 displaced the venerable *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi* in the first week of January), to Kanpur for *Santaan* and to Palampur, Himachal Pradesh, for the brand new *Raja ki Aayegi Baraat*. Star Plus's Senior Creative Director Vivek Bahl, who earlier worked on the trend-setting *Saat Phere* on Zee TV, heads the team that caters to small town viewers who want reaffirmation and big city viewers with "reverse aspirations", which translated from television jargon means the comfort of unchanging tradition. Says Bahl: "I think at some point soaps were becoming too plastic. These new

shows deal with more realistic characters and everyday issues." Well, almost—the problems usually centre around marriage (of dark daughter versus fair cousin in *Bidaai*), children (generation gap over flashy lifestyle in *Santaan*) and romance (poor servant mistaken for princess and the confusion that follows in *Raja...*).

This ethnic flavour (which in 2000 was restricted to the Gujarati Viranis in *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi*, the Agarwals in *Kahaani Ghar Ghar Ki* and the Basus in *Kasautii Zindagi Kay*) is now reaping the benefits of a new talent catchment in terms of directors and actors. So while *Bidaai* is produced by newcomer Rajan Shahi, one of its two lead stars, Sarah Khan, was Miss Bhopal. As Bahl, who grew up in Mumbai but spent many holidays with grandparents in Jabalpur and Delhi